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Evaluating autism support programs in higher education through the perspectives of students, parents, counselors and staff

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Introduction: Some postsecondary institutions have established Autism Support Programs (ASP) that provide specialized support for autistic college students.
Methods: This work investigates the structure and experience of these programs through thirty-four semi-structured interviews with participants from four stakeholder groups: ASP staff, autistic college students, parents of autistic college students, and high school staff who have worked with college-bound autistic students.
Results: Participants reported ASPs offering an array of academic, social and environmental support. Parents and students indicated that participating in an ASP was helpful in multiple facets of the college experience, including academic planning, social integration, and independent living. All groups reported high levels of satisfaction with ASP offerings; however, ASP staff reported little to no use of quantitative measures of academic or post-graduation outcomes.
Discussion: Significant barriers to access remain. Students, parents and high school staff report difficulty finding information about ASPs, leading to a reliance on informal communication networks. Finally, program cost and limited enrollment capacity may result in diminished access to resources for students who may benefit from an ASP. Specific recommendations for secondary education professionals, ASP staff and state agencies to improve access to ASPs are provided.

KEYWORDS
autism support programs, education accessibility, higher education, post-secondary transition, young adults

Introduction

An increasing number of autistic students are seeking postsecondary education (Bakker et al., 2019; Cox et al., 2026). Autistic students who transition to higher education frequently encounter a range of complex challenges including academics, social isolation, mental health, co-occurring conditions like ADHD, and difficulties with executive functioning (Elias et al., 2019; Jackson et al., 2018; Rosenau et al., 2023; Roux et al., 2024; Santhanam and Wilson, 2024; Wolpe, 2024). Considering these factors, low attainment of postsecondary degrees among adults with ASD is not unexpected (Shattuck et al., 2012).

Autism support programs

In K-12 educational settings, students with an ASD diagnosis are offered many therapeutic and social supports embedded in their educational programming (Suhrheinrich, et al., 2021). These supports are provided by practitioners and often guided by parent advocacy that promotes access to supports required for successful educational outcomes (Nachman et al., 2024). When transitioning to postsecondary education, college applicants with ASD may be academically prepared for the rigors of higher education (Petcu, et al., 2021); however, autistic traits including challenges with social and communication skills, executive functioning, and flexible thinking impact successful integration into college life (Locke, et al., 2024).

Accommodations under the Americans with Disabilities Act of 1990 (ADA) and Rehabilitation Act of 1973 are mandated in the U.S., but provide only a minimal, legally required level of access. Although disability services offices must offer academic accommodations, such as extended testing time, they may not address the broader psychosocial and emotional needs of this unique population (Accardo et al., 2019; Blaskowitz et al., 2025). Beyond this legally mandated baseline, some postsecondary institutions have established specialized Autism Support Programs (ASPs) tailored to the strengths and challenges unique to autistic students (Barnhill, 2016). ASPs may include accommodations in compliance with the ADA, but programs are voluntarily created and vary by institution. Accordingly, we define ASPs as programs meeting at least one of the following characteristics: (a) advertising or promoting the program as an ASP; (b) eligibility for the program is restricted to students specifically diagnosed with ASD, rather than being open to students with disabilities generally; and (c) services and supports tailored to the needs of autistic students as opposed to students with other disabilities (e.g., intellectual disabilities, learning disabilities). Critically, an ASP is defined by identifying itself as such and tailoring its services specifically to autistic students; a disability services office that serves autistic students among a general disability population does not, on that basis alone, constitute an ASP. However, we acknowledge that ASPs can exist within the organizational structure of a disabilities services office.

Previous reviews have identified common elements of ASPs and notable distinctions among them (Barnhill, 2016; Viezel et al., 2020; Nachman et al., 2022; West et al., 2025). ASPs often pair students with a learning strategist or academic mentor who helps with time management, organization, and executive functioning rather than course content. Structured social programming and peer mentors aim to ease integration into campus life. Self-advocacy support assists students in communicating their needs to professors and campus offices as parental involvement recedes. Going beyond what disability services offices are required to provide makes ASPs a promising avenue for supporting autistic students in higher education.

Despite the promise of ASPs in helping autistic students access higher education, it is unclear how prospective students, their parents, and high school counselors learn about ASPs or whether they are accessible and appropriate for all autistic students. Only 133 of the 3,562-degree granting postsecondary institutions in the U.S. report hosting an ASP (West et al., 2025); however, prospective students and their parents are offered minimal guidance on which institutions offer them. While high school guidance counselors are well versed in postsecondary educational opportunities for neurotypical students, their skillsets may not include knowledge of postsecondary support for autistic students (Dipeolu et al., 2014). Furthermore, the requirements to access an ASP such as diagnostic criteria, documentation of needs, and application requirements vary greatly between institutions (Viezel et al., 2020; Barbour, 2025). Additionally, previous research has found that 78% of programs require a fee in addition to tuition with a median cost of $3,670 (West et al., 2025). Such factors represent accessibility challenges for students who would benefit from an ASP.

Studies exploring accommodations and support preferences of autistic students in postsecondary settings provide insights into the needs and challenges of degree seeking autistic students (Wolpe, 2024). While a growing body of work documents the lived experiences of autistic students in higher education generally (Cox et al., 2026; Nachman et al., 2025), there is minimal inquiry on the lived experiences of students enrolled specifically in ASPs. Therefore, it remains ambiguous whether the services provided by ASPs benefit autistic students and their families. Further, it is unclear what specific types of support these programs offer, and whether they align with evidence-based practice for this population. Without a clear understanding of the scope, structure, and merit of services, it is difficult to assess ASP impact.

In addition to whether ASPs are accessible and provide services that align with students' support needs, it is crucial to consider whether they improve the key outcomes they are designed to address (e.g., graduation within prescribed timeframes, employment upon graduation, satisfaction with services and positive college experience). The extent to which ASP offerings align with the individual non-academic objectives of autistic students, such as fostering independence, enhancing social engagement, and supporting career readiness remains unclear (Wolpe, 2024; Watson, et al., 2024). Furthermore, it is not known whether these programs gather feedback from students to inform their evaluative and improvement practices, or whether their offerings are based on evolving research of effective methods (Kuder and Accardo, 2018). Without clear mechanisms for assessment and adaptation, ASPs may not meet the changing needs of the students they aim to support.

Purpose of the current study

The present study expands upon existing research exploring ASPs from the perspectives of four key stakeholder groups—students who have received ASP services, parents whose children have attended an ASP, ASP staff, and high school professionals who support autistic student transitions—with the following questions (Accardo et al., 2019; Elias et al., 2019; Jackson et al., 2018; Santhanam and Wilson, 2024):

- How do students and families identify which postsecondary institutions offer ASPs?

- What barriers do they face in accessing the services that are offered?
- Are the services offered aligned with their perceived support needs?
- What are the experiences of students who participate in ASPs?
- Are ASPs successful in helping students attain key outcomes?

Our inquiry has identified knowledge gaps between the stakeholder groups and provides recommendations for improvements to the ASP search process.

Method

Positionality

This research emerged from an interdisciplinary team of doctoral students and professors of Special Education, Organizational Psychology, and Computer Science. Team members offered unique perspectives related to their field of study, practice, and experiences with neurodivergence. Special Education team members contributed their perspective of teaching students with autism and establishing relationships with students and their families as well as the breadth of current research involving autism support in schools. Team members in Organizational Psychology and Computer Science contributed their expertise in accessible information technology and human-computer interaction, and knowledge of organization systems within secondary and postsecondary institutions. The third author, a professor of special education and applied behavior analysis with over 30 years of research and practice experience in the provision of supports to autistic adults, oversaw the qualitative analysis. He developed the initial qualitative codebook and supervised the coding which was conducted in collaboration with the first and second authors, doctoral students in computer science (first author) and special education (second author). The second author had extensive experience as a teacher of students with complex communication needs, including autism. Interdisciplinary team meetings occurred frequently to contribute unique perspectives throughout the development and execution of the project. Our shared purpose was to expand access to postsecondary education for autistic students requiring additional support through our expertise in student needs derived from personal experience, research, and access to information about beneficial programming. The diverse perspectives on our team have shaped this inquiry into a shared understanding of *what* students need from an ASP, and *how* we can disseminate that information across stakeholders. All members of the research team are included as authors.

Inclusion criteria

We identified four groups of stakeholders who play a significant role in an autistic college student's experience: students, parents of autistic students enrolled in an ASP, ASP staff, and high school staff who support autistic students transitioning to postsecondary education. The experience of students attending ASPs is central to our research. The primary means by which students interact with ASPs is through program staff. Staff members are employed by the university and oversee admission to ASPs, manage peer mentors, organize events for participants, and academic advising. Some staff members may simultaneously hold other roles within the university. Parents play a prominent role in the search for a postsecondary institution and thus the search for, and evaluation of ASPs. High school staff, guidance counselors, teachers and administrators provide key information regarding postsecondary opportunities to autistic students.

This study was approved by the Temple University Institutional Review Board (approval #30718) before recruitment and data collection. All participants provided written informed consent for participation, recording of interviews and publication prior to beginning their interviews. Inclusion criteria for each stakeholder group were:

Students identified as autistic, were currently enrolled in a postsecondary education institution, including a 2-year institution, 4-year institution, or graduate program, and currently receiving or previously received support from an ASP.

Parents had an autistic child meeting the student criteria. In some cases, both the parent and their child participated in the study; in these cases, the interviews were conducted separately. All students were their own legal decision makers; no parents were legal guardians with power of attorney.

ASP staff were currently employed by an ASP. High school staff had previous professional experience with college-bound students who identified as autistic.

Participants and recruitment

Thirty-four (34) participants completed semi-structured interviews:

- ten (10) ASP staff
- nine (9) students
- seven (7) parents
- eight (8) high school staff

ASP and high school staff were contacted via email addresses on institutional websites. Students were primarily recruited via snowball sampling ($n = 7$) by asking ASP staff participants to share recruitment materials with the students enrolled in their programs. Additionally, flyers were posted on select college campuses seeking student participants ($n = 2$). Parents were recruited using social media groups. Recruitment materials consisted of an email describing the purpose of the study and a flyer describing the inclusion criteria, duration of the study, compensation for participation and a QR code to a Google form to express interest. Participants who completed the Google Form were contacted by a researcher to ensure they met the inclusion criteria. Demographic data can be found in Tables 1–4. Most notably, participants overwhelmingly identified as female for all stakeholder groups, with the exception of students who were roughly evenly distributed between male and female identities. Participants were distributed across 15 distinct post-secondary

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TABLE 1 Demographics for student participants.

ID	Diagnosis primary	Diagnosis secondary	Gender	Age	Race	Major	School Type	Year in school	Degree type
S1	ASD	ADHD	Female	19	White	Art and visual technology	Research University—Public	2nd year	Bachelors
S2	ASD	ADHD	Female	19	White	Environment science	Liberal Arts College—Public	1st year	Bachelors
S3	ASD	ADHD	Male	20	White	Criminal justice	Research University—Public	2nd year	Bachelors
S4	ASD	ADHD and social anxiety disorder	Male	26	White	Nursing	Liberal Arts College—Public	3rd year	Bachelors
S5	ASD	None reported	Male	21	White	Communications	Liberal Arts College—Public	3rd year	Bachelors
S6	ASD	Schizophrenic disorder bipolar type and PTSD	Female	25	White	Library science	Liberal Arts College—Public	3rd year	Bachelors
S7	ASD	ADHD and Anxiety	Male	22	White	History	Research University—Public	4th year	Bachelors
S8	ASD	None reported	Female	21	Asian American	Music	Research University—Public	4th year	Bachelors
S9	ASD	None reported	Male	21	African American	Information technology	Research University—Public	3rd year	Bachelors

This table describes the demographics of student participants in this study. We did not collect data on socio-economic status (SES) for this group.
ASD, autism spectrum disorder; ADHD, attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder.

TABLE 2 Demographics for parent participants.

ID	Gender	Age	Race	Highest education level	Child's school type
P1	Female	56	African American	Graduate degree	Community College
P2	Female	52	White	Bachelors degree	Research University—Private
P3	Female	53	White	Bachelors degree	Research University—Public
P4	Female	54	White	Graduate degree	Research University—Public
P5	Female	58	White	Bachelors degree	Liberal Arts College—Private
P6	Female	59	White	Bachelors degree	Liberal Arts College—Private
P7	Female	56	White	Bachelors degree	Liberal Arts College—Private

This table describes the demographics of parent participants in this study. We did not collect data on SES for this group.

TABLE 3 Demographic for high school staff participants.

ID	Job title	Gender	Age	Years of experience	Race	Highest education level	School type
HS1	High school counselor	Female	51	20	White	Graduate degree	Private high school
HS2	Postsecondary education counselor	Female	47	8	White	Graduate degree	Public high school
HS3	Guidance counselor	Female	52	12	White	Graduate degree	Public high school
HS4	Director of transition	Female	32	12	White	Graduate degree	Private high school
HS5	Counselor	Female	33	7	White	Graduate degree	Public high school
HS6	Autistic support teacher	Female	53	21	White	Graduate degree	Public high school
HS7	Special education teacher	Female	50	6	White	Graduate degree	Private high school
HS8	Principal	Male	50	6	White	Graduate degree	Private high school

This table describes the demographics of high school staff participants in this study. We did not collect data on SES for this group.

TABLE 4 Demographics for ASP staff participants.

ID	Job title	Gender	Age	Years of experience	Race	Highest education level	School type
AS1	Director	Female	35	4	White	Graduate degree	Research University—Public
AS2	Program manager/support specialist	Female	33	4	Hispanic/Latino	Graduate degree	Research University—Public
AS3	Director	Female	28	2	Hispanic/Latino	Graduate degree	Liberal Arts College—Private
AS4	Director	Female	45	2	White	Graduate degree	Liberal Arts College—Public
AS5	Graduate assistant	Female	22	1	White	Bachelors degree	Liberal Arts College—Public
AS6	Director	Female	71	30	White	Graduate degree	Community College—Public
AS7	Director	Female	38	11	White	Graduate degree	Research University—Public
AS8	Learning strategist	Male	26	2	White	Graduate degree	Research University—Public
AS9	Intern	Female	22	1	White	Bachelors degree	Liberal Arts College—Public
AS10	Learning strategist	Female	42	1	Asian American	Graduate degree	Research University—Public

This table describes the demographics of ASP staff participants in this study. We did not collect data on SES for this group.

TABLE 5 Participant distribution across institutions.

Institution	ASP staff	Parent	Student	Institution type	Instituition size	Geographic region
C1	3	0	3	Liberal Arts College—Public	Small	South
C2	1	1	1	Liberal Arts College—Private	Small	South
C3	2	0	1	Research University—Public	Large	South
C4	1	0	1	Research University—Public	Large	South
C5	0	1	1	Research University—Public	Large	Northeast
C6	1	0	0	Community College	Medium	Northeast
C7	0	1	0	Community College	Large	West
C8	0	1	0	Liberal Arts College—Private	Medium	Northeast
C9	0	0	1	Research University—Public	Large	West
C10	0	1	0	Research University—Public	Large	South
C11	0	0	1	Research University—Public	Large	Northeast
C12	1	0	0	Research University—Public	Large	Northeast
C13	0	1	0	Research University—Private	Small	South
C14	1	0	0	Research University—Public	Medium	South
C15	0	1	0	Liberal Arts College—Private	Small	West

High school staff participants ($n = 8$) are not represented, as they were not affiliated with a specific ASP institution. Institution size is grouped by total undergraduate population (Small <5,000, Medium 5,000–15,000, Large >15,000). Geographic regions correspond to U.S. Census regions.

institutions (Table 5). One-hour semi-structured interviews were conducted via Zoom. Interviews were recorded and transcribed for data analysis. Participants were compensated with a $50 gift card.

Interview procedures

Interview questions explored the experiences of autistic college students and the community supporting them. Three main themes

guided the construction of interview questions: (a) challenges experienced prior to and in college; (b) the college search process and discovery of ASPs; (c) the support offered, and needs addressed by ASPs. The research team developed four semi-structured interview scripts, one for each stakeholder group which can be found on the OSF project page.

Student and parent questions explored the process of identifying the right program and the role of ASPs in supporting students. For example, we asked our student participants, "What would an ideal ASP offer to best support your needs?" We asked parents, "What are some barriers, obstacles or pain points that you anticipate experiencing or have experienced when looking for or considering ASPs?" For ASP and high school staff, specific questions were written to determine general characteristics of the population of students they work with. For example, high school counselors were asked, "When your students are seeking postsecondary education, how do they typically decide which institutions to consider?" while ASP staff questions were more program specific, "What would you say are some common challenges that your students encounter before they are enrolled in this program?"

Interviews were conducted between April 2024 and March 2025. Two or more members of the research team were present. One researcher conducted the interview while the other took notes and recorded the session. Interviews followed semi-structured scripts, and attending researchers asked clarifying, follow-up and probing questions when appropriate. All interviews were conducted, recorded and transcribed via Zoom. Interview questions were reviewed and edited by the research team early in the data collection period. Scripts were revised when we identified opportunities to collect more robust data or align questions to represent emerging characteristics of participant groups.

Coding development and data analysis

Interview transcripts were analyzed in Dedoose (2025), a software platform for qualitative and mixed-methods data analysis, using inductive content analysis (Assarroudi et al., 2018; Erlingsson and Brysiewicz, 2017). We did not use AI in the qualitative analysis process. The senior researcher initially read and coded the transcripts, identifying units of meaning related to the research questions and assigning preliminary codes that closely reflected participants' responses. Related codes were compared and organized, as appropriate, into subcategories or broader categories. For example, when asked about the kinds of services the ASPs were providing, participants identified services such as peer mentoring, social events, academic support, and housing accommodations. These codes were grouped into the broader category, ASP Supports Provided to Students. At the conclusion of the analysis process, we identified 18 categories with their associated subcategories, which can be found in the Appendix.

Two other members of the research team, doctoral students in computer science and special education. then independently coded the transcripts using the preliminary codebook. Initially, the team members compared their results and discussed any instances of non-agreement. This training process continued until the team was able to consistently code transcripts with 80% agreement. When new codes emerged or existing codes needed to be adjusted, reorganized, or removed, the team met to discuss these decisions; additional codes were applied, and original codes refined. This process was repeated until saturation was achieved (i.e., no new codes could be identified). To ensure the accuracy of coding, additional rounds of blind double coding were conducted by two team members. Team members met after each round of double coding was completed to discuss discrepancies and reach agreement. Interobserver agreement met the threshold of over 80% agreement throughout the coding process. Finally, the team compared categories within and between stakeholder groups and developed overarching themes to address each of the study's research questions.

Results

We identified key findings from interviews conducted with all four stakeholder groups. Qualitative analyses revealed recurring themes suggesting strong consensus and notable discrepancies among stakeholder groups. We organize these themes according to the major research questions guiding the investigation, that is, how do students and families identify which postsecondary institutions offer ASPs and what barriers do they face in accessing services? (i.e., access); are the services offered aligned with their perceived support needs? (i.e., service offerings); what are the experiences of students who participate in ASPs and are ASPs successful in helping students attain key outcomes? (i.e., outcomes). We outline the distinct perspectives of each stakeholder group and highlight the shared understanding between groups.

Accessing ASPs

We anchor our first set of findings to issues of accessing ASPs. Access addresses factors related to how parents, students, and high school staff learn about ASPs, the costs associated with the services, and whether a student's choice to attend a school or ASP is related to its proximity to their home.

Lack of information about ASPs

Across all stakeholder groups, a consistent theme emerged: information about ASPs is scarce and, often, communicated informally. High school staff displayed varying knowledge of ASP services at postsecondary institutions and primarily identified ASPs by informal experience and word of mouth. Those that reported ongoing relationships with postsecondary institutions ($n = 4$) only reported relationships with local community colleges. In these cases, they indicated that while the community college provided autism specific support, they did not host a formal ASP. High school staff also reported their schools hosting transition fairs or information sessions attended or hosted by local community colleges ($n = 4$). Consequently, parents and students seeking other options reported having to use their own resources to identify ASPs.

Parents took an active role in outreach to colleges, and assessing programs with their child. When asked about college search, students stated information was provided by their parents or used "we" and "us" to describe the process. S1 described the process of finding an ASP with her mom's support, "She just found out about it and was like, hey, we should maybe try applying at [my university], see if they would let us in," while S5 bluntly stated, "My mother pushed me towards [my university]." Notably, all parents included in this study ($n = 7$) held at least a Bachelor's degree, indicating personal experience with higher education.

Some ASP staff ($n = 6$) reported relationships with local high schools, while others reported avoiding active recruitment due to lack of capacity in the program. AS1 noted, "We do work out in the community and so sometimes people hear about [our program] that way, but we don't do a lot of publicity because it's a small program." Program capacity was a theme underscoring lack of program advertising and outreach; some ASP staff ($n = 4$) reported there was little need to advertise because their program was full and/or there was a substantial waitlist for admission. The small program size was attributed to lack of available funding for additional staff and other program costs.

Cost

Cost can be a barrier to accessing ASPs, as most programs require a fee in addition to tuition. Most ASP staff ($n = 8$) reported external funding or scholarship availability to ensure that students do not bear the cost. AS1 stated, "I keep our program funded with grants..in the world of disability everything is behind a paywall and students have a right to access." However, they also noted that this limits the number of spots in the program "We keep the program small, but it is now full." The most common source of external funding was Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) offices, state agencies that provide funding to support employment related activities, including access to higher education for individuals with disabilities. Some ASP staff reported assisting students in accessing financial assistance from VR ($n = 2$), while one parent reported accessing these resources without assistance ($n = 1$). A high school counselor noted a lack of transparency about services available through VR, while P3 stated, "As a Pennsylvania resident we knew that OVR would cover the cost." For S4, their OVR counselor assisted in the search process in addition to funding. When asked if he independently searched for ASPs, S4 stated, "No, the vast majority of it was, handled by my case worker in voc(ational) rehab, they helped out a great deal."

Location

An overwhelming majority of students pursued higher education at a university near their hometown ($n = 8$). An equal number reported living in on-campus housing (27.7%) and non-family off-campus housing (27.7%), while 44.6% remained in their parents' home. When deciding between two programs S6 stated, "[My university] is closer to my house, to my family," as being the deciding factor to enroll at that school. Students and parents both reported significant parental involvement with their child's education after matriculation. A desire for continued parental support may be a play a role in the decision to stay close to home.

Service offerings

Our second set of findings relates to the nature of ASP service offerings and how they align to students' needs. This includes supports provided during the transition to postsecondary education, and the nature of college-based academic, social, environmental, and self-advocacy supports.

Pre-college support and accommodations

High school staff represented the most diverse group of participants including individuals from public, private and charter institutions. They provided information about autistic students including academic track, and in school supports. They noted that they worked with autistic students with a wide range of academic experience; of these students, only a small portion were seeking or successfully accessing higher education opportunities. This contrasts with our student participants, who were homogeneously high-performing academically prior to college. The divergence between the population of students described by high school staff and the population of students included in this study is expected given the structure of ASP admissions; in each of the programs represented in our data, students must first be admitted to the institution through standard channels before enrolling in the ASP.

High school guidance counselors were often tasked with identifying colleges with appropriate support. HS1 described effective outreach, "We have somebody that does a presentation to our parents, just kind of delineating all the opportunities that are out there." HS2 described the process as, "It is a little bit like a needle in a haystack." High school staff indicated that most autistic students seeking higher education begin at a local community college.

Services

Academic supports

Every student and parent interviewed reported pre-college academic accommodations through an IEP or 504 Plan ($n = 9$ students, 7 parents). Students reported receiving some form of accommodation at the postsecondary level through the schools' Disability Office, such as extended time for tests ($n = 9$). In addition, every student and ASP staff member reported some form of academic support as part of the ASP ($n = 9$ students, 10 ASP staff). The most common form of academic support reported was regular meetings with a Learning Strategist or Academic Mentor. S6 described these meetings saying, "She helps me figure out a plan every week of when my due dates are and how I'm gonna get my stuff done". Other forms of academic support included a study hall with tutors, study spaces and a one credit course focused on organization and executive functioning.

Social supports

Social skills and social isolation were reported by parents ($n = 4$), ASP staff ($n = 3$) and high school staff ($n = 2$) as the most common challenge students faced. However, no students mentioned social skills or isolation when asked about challenges they faced in college. Despite this discrepancy, social support was reported as an aspect of ASPs by every stakeholder group ($n = 7$ students, 3 parents, 8 ASP staff). Every student and ASP staff reported the program including some kind of social event ($n = 9$ students, 10 ASP staff). Most students and staff reported the program utilizing peer mentors to help students engage socially on campus ($n = 5$ students, 6 ASP staff). S2 described their relationship with their peer mentor, saying "they're kind of our good friends and they help us with stuff and we meet with them weekly". Additionally, staff and students reported social skills support such as social skills workshops, guidance on appropriate classroom behavior and assistance in engaging with campus activities or groups.

Environmental supports

Each university is unique when creating physical spaces for their ASP students. Some schools provide services but lack physical space for their programs, while others have a dedicated ASP department with sensory rooms and study spaces ($n = 1$). P2 described the tour of her daughter's school, "[The University] actually has an entire department that has, you know, a whole section of a building and they have quiet rooms, and they have sensory rooms, and they have weekly support meetings." Select programs also offer supportive dorms for autistic students ($n = 3$ ASP staff, 2 parents). For students who did not have supported living options, most were aware that they could apply for a single room through the Disability Office.

Self-advocacy

ASP staff emphasized supporting students with self-advocacy. The most common support was assistance in communication with professors and other campus resources ($n = 6$). S3 described a call to the university disability office, "The program director joined me in that call, just to make sure they'll provide stuff like as needed where they're making sure, I'm receiving (supports)." Student self-advocacy was a notable transition for parents, who previously acted as the primary advocates for their child in primary and secondary education. P7 noted "Unlike high school, they're trying to teach her to take responsibility or kind of putting the onus more on her to communicate with you."

Outcomes

Our final set of findings relates to outcomes of ASPs. That is, how effective do students and parents believe the services are in meeting their support needs and what efforts do staff make in evaluating their programs towards continued improvement.

Student perspective on effectiveness

Students generally described positive attitudes towards ASPs. Feeling supported was a shared sentiment expressed about their experience at college and in ASPs ($n = 4$). As S1 put it, "It's a very nice school. Very supportive, very understanding, I receive the help that I need." Student participants offered minimal insight into changes or improvement to their ASP, suggesting overall positive experiences. Alternatively, this may imply a lack of self-advocacy and social assertiveness among these students. One common request for a change to ASP programming was more student-directed social activities ($n = 3$). S8 stated when asked what kind of social activity they would prefer, "Probably stuff that we could manage more by ourselves like..meeting up playing video games just hanging out at a restaurant or store."

Parent perspective

Parents play an integral role in the college search process, but their involvement is curtailed as their child enters college. Each program has its own approach ranging from weekly emails to parents, to only contacting parents with an issue. Some parents, who were deeply involved in the selection process, perceived an information gap about the needs and progress of their child ($n = 4$). P5 noted, "They'll update you like once and then..if his case manager contacts me, I'm like, uh-oh." Despite this concern, parents generally reported positive sentiment towards ASPs and supportive atmospheres that helped their children. As P4 stated, "It definitely worked really well to help him acclimate to his new environment."

Program self evaluation

All programs reported using student feedback as a method of evaluation. Other methods were student academic performance and student goal attainment. Some programs also reported incorporating parent and professor feedback ($n = 2$), as well as student retention in the program ($n = 1$). Program staff did not appear to engage in formal program evaluation as AS8 stated, "we're always listening to, you know, parent professor and student feedback. And I think that is the gist of it."

Discussion

This study explored access, experiences and outcomes related to post-secondary ASPs by interviewing four key stakeholder groups. Our findings reveal significant knowledge gaps between the four stakeholder groups and highlight areas for improvement that may enhance students' access to these programs.

Accessing ASPs

Lack of information about ASPs

Our findings confirm previous research which has noted a lack of systematic post-secondary transition support for autistic

students (Shattuck, et al., 2012; Roux et al., 2024; Blaskowitz, et. al,. 2025). Internet searches using popular search engines fail to reveal accurate information about many ASPs (West et al, 2025). Students, parents and high school staff learn about ASPs primarily through informal, word of mouth channels. This reliance on informal information networks creates significant information gaps. Families with college experience, such as those included in this study, must exert significant personal effort to piece together a picture of the support available to them. These families likely have some knowledge of the "hidden curriculum" (Alsubaie, 2015) including the ways in which higher education bureaucracies may be navigated and successful advocacy may be pursued. For example, simply knowing such seemingly basic facts such as that a disabilities services office exists in every USA higher education institution, or that the IEP and 504 plans followed in high school are not applicable to a university education may spur these parents to search for accommodations for their child. In contrast, families without college experience must rely on information from high school staff and may be left unaware of the support available.

A primary practical step is creation and annual maintenance of a formal, centralized resource hub of regional ASP and college disability support services that is readily findable via a basic internet search and easily searchable. This may be maintained by a large school district, a state department of education or a state VR agency and may be modeled after the Provider Locators which are maintained by various state VR agencies (Texas Workforce Commission, 2025). It should contain actionable details for students and parents, such as program costs, application processes, key contacts and student outcome data. To facilitate effective use of this resource, school districts should partner with ASP staff to host professional development series for high school counselors. Such a series should not be a one-time event, but rather a key component of an ongoing, formal relationship between ASPs and local high schools. Finally, the information from this resource hub and professional development series should be integrated into the transition planning of all autistic students. This ensures that a review of college support is routine, not reliant on the initiative of the families, which may be particularly impactful for potential first-generation college students.

Small program sizes

The small capacity of existing ASPs suggests an imbalance between the increasing need for support and the availability of services at universities. Several ASP staff members cited small program capacity as the reason they did not engage in outreach or advertising, noting they lacked the resources to expand the program ($n = 4$). Despite limited outreach, some ASP staff noted that their programs still had waiting lists ($n = 3$), indicating a greater demand for ASP services than current programs can provide. Given our findings that students, parents and high school staff often struggle to identify ASPs, existing wait lists likely underrepresent the true demand for services. While the desire from ASP staff to not have to turn students away is understandable, their lack of outreach leaves the true demand undocumented, which may make it harder to advocate for greater resources from university administrators and perpetuate the capacity issue.

Cost

Funding limitations restrict program capacity and accessibility for students. Respondents indicated some ASPs rely on external funding to offer free services ($n = 3$); however, this limited program capacity. Other programs use a fee-based model, which presents an economic barrier ($n = 4$). While some ASP staff and students reported funding from their states' VR office ($n = 3$), it is not clear that this funding is offered in every state or accessible for students seeking higher education outside their state of residence (Rast et al., 2020; Sulewski et al., 2021).

Location

Most students sought higher education close to home ($n = 8$). Continued parental support may be the driving factor in choosing local options. Notably, all students and parents included in our study attended, or had a child that attended, a 4-year institution. This is likely due to our use of snowball sampling of ASP staff at 4-year institutions. Conversely, high school staff reported their experience with college bound autistic students centered on community or technical colleges after high school. Minimal evidence of ASPs offered at community colleges suggests a service gap at the community college level underexplored in literature (Nachman et al., 2022).

Services

Academic supports

All stakeholder groups indicated that students entering ASPs were on par or high achieving academically. Yet participants indicated that ASP services always included some sort of academic support, such as meetings with ASP staff to discuss assignments and timelines or mandatory study hall participation. In a previous survey with autistic college students, most reported discomfort with their academic workload (Jackson, et al., 2018). While students may not require support with the content of their work, they often struggle with time management, organization, and executive functioning skills. The academic support offered by ASPs focuses on these aspects of academic work. Content focused academic support, such as tutoring or writing workshops, was not commonly within the scope of ASP services, but students reported using the writing center or disability office to access these supports if needed.

Social supports

Social supports reported by multiple stakeholder groups fell into two categories: direct social support and social skills support. Direct social support involved regular meetings with peer mentors and program wide social events. Students reported mixed feelings regarding program wide social events; some students enjoyed the events while others felt they were an obligation more than a support. S1 stated, "They require you to go to some social events..you to do activities that are kind of childish in my opinion". Making social events more

independent and student directed was a common suggestion ($n = 3$). Interestingly, social skills and social isolation were reported as a common challenge students faced by every stakeholder group except for the students themselves. It is unclear if this discrepency is due to a difference in perceived challenges among the groups or if it indicates that ASPs are effectively addressing this challenge, as all student participants in this study were enrolled in an ASP.

In addition to direct social support, ASPs reported social skills training opportunities, such as informational sessions, social skills workshops, and program-specific courses. While some students found the sessions helpful, others found them unnecessary. However, the latter group frequently reported that they felt the sessions were helpful for other students, suggesting that they are a critical piece of ASPs even if they do not benefit all participants equally.

Self-Advocacy

Many participants report that self-advocacy is a focal point in ASPs. Students described it as teaching "independence", including sending emails to professors with their accommodations and improving general communication with professional staff and peers on campus. Increased self-advocacy is tied to the evolving relationship between students and their parents (Nachman, 2024). Parents are the primary advocates for their school age child and are heavily involved in the college search process. This involvement extends through matriculation, as parents take a leading role in ensuring accommodations through disability offices and ASPs. However, once enrolled in an ASP, the focus on student self-advocacy reduces direct parental involvement. This transition gave some parents a sense of anxiety surrounding their new, less involved role ($n = 3$).

Mentorship

Mentorship is a key component in ASPs (Morris, et al., 2024). Mentors range from student volunteers to graduate students or professional staff. Mentorship programs involve support across the dimensions of academics, social skills, and self-advocacy. The mentor/mentee relationship provides mutual benefits with mentees gaining skills including reading non-verbal cues and self-awareness. Mentors are provided training on how to support autistic peers, give situational feedback in social settings and set goals with their mentee (Locke, et al., 2024). Peer mentors play a particularly important role in ASPs, acting as a social conduit helping students integrate into the larger campus community (Morris, et al., 2024). ASP staff and students reported that peer mentors are generally undergraduate students, drawn from the psychology and education departments implying that they have some academic understanding of autism. Students generally reported positive experiences with peer mentors, however S5 noted some variation "My freshman year [the peer mentor program] was filled with the best people imaginable for it..But you know, you get a new batch of people in and they might not be as good".

Duration of service

ASP staff indicate that support is available but not required for the duration of a student's academic program within the university. Most ASPs only support undergraduate students; however, we interviewed one student able to continue their services into their graduate degree. The students, parents and ASP staff we interviewed all indicated that programs tend to offer a system of tiered support individualized to reflect shifting student needs as they move through their college experience. S7 described his experience with tiered support, "I moved from one tier, which was you have weekly meetings..and then go to a group social, but now I'm in a tier where I [attend] biweekly meetings..and I can choose between group and social. "

Outcomes

ASPs provide autistic students a supportive environment with physical spaces, mentoring programs and social events offering continued support in academic and non-academic aspects of their college experience. The implicit goal of these supports is to improve key outcomes for autistic students. The question remains, how effective are ASPs at delivering desirable outcomes, and how do ASPs measure effectiveness?

ASP outcomes

ASP staff participants did not indicate regular use of formal measurement tools for student outcomes. Programs often relied on informal feedback from students, professors, and parents. Some programs reported monitoring students' academic performance or student retention within the program as methods of self-evaluation, but these were not widespread or systematic.

The absence of formal measurement of student outcomes represents a significant gap in understanding ASP effectiveness. Common metrics used on a university wide basis, such as GPA, graduation rate, graduation time, and student retention could offer insight into whether ASPs improve the academic outcomes they are designed to support. Further, post-graduation metrics, such as employment rate and salary by field of study, would reveal whether the benefits students and parents report translate into longer-term outcomes. Systematically collected quantitative data of this kind would not only clarify program impact for researchers and institutions considering establishing an ASP, but would also allow program staff to better advocate for resources from university administrators and grant-issuing agencies to address the growing demand for ASPs.

Limitations

Snowball sampling, particularly for parents and students, may have introduced biases. Parents, students and ASP staff with positive program experiences may have been more likely to participate, potentially skewing results. High school staff participants all had experience directly supporting autistic

students, however, their knowledge of ASPs showed significant variation. Qualitative analysis is inherently subjective. Our coding processes and interpretations may have influenced the identification and emphasis of themes. Inter-coder reliability measures were implemented to mitigate this, but subjectivity cannot be eliminated entirely.

For both ASP and high school staff, inclusion criteria allowed individuals who perform a variety of roles to participate in the study. ASP staff included participants from Program Directors to Peer Counselors, while high school staff included Principals to Guidance Counselors. This diversity reflects real-world structures and people who support autistic students but may limit the generalization of staff perspectives. Nevertheless, we gained insight from all participants about the transition to college life for autistic students.

We acknowledge unequal participation across stakeholder groups. Data for this study were collected over a year and active recruitment took place throughout our interview process. We considered continuing recruitment; however, through analysis of the data we determined that saturation was achieved for lower participant groups. Additional interviews would prolong the publication of results without significant affect to the findings. Future inquiries may benefit from seeking stakeholder voices less prominent in this study (e.g., parents and high school staff).

Future directions and recommendations

We identified a need for enhanced communication between ASP staff, high schools, VR counselors, and families. The development of a centralized resource hub that includes program applications, eligibility requirements and available services would decrease reliance on word-of-mouth, easing the search process for families. This would be particularly impactful for potential first-generation college students, who are not familiar with the "hidden curriculum" of postsecondary institutions. Future research may investigate the efficacy of different outreach methods to disseminate ASP information to high school staff and families. A comparative study could evaluate the impact of a workshop with high school counselors versus family-focused information sessions on student application and enrollment rates in ASPs.

Increased outreach efforts can result in greater demand for ASPs. Program growth requires increased staffing and overall program funding. ASP staff are hesitant to introduce a waiting list. However, programs can use the presence of a waiting list and program metrics to advocate for resources from university administrators and grant issuing agencies. Future research could investigate scalable and sustainable models for ASP growth. A study of the programmatic, staffing and funding structure of existing ASPs that have successfully managed to expand could serve as a blueprint for other programs to increase their capacity.

While some ASP staff and students reported that they received funding from their states' VR, it is not clear that this funding is offered in every state or for students who seek higher education outside their state of residence. Future work may investigate VR funding for ASP fees across states. Additionally, several high school staff reported an emphasis on community college attendance for most of their autistic students who went on to seek higher education. Future research may investigate what proportion of autistic students attend community colleges and ASPs or equivalent service offerings at the community college level.

Conclusion

ASPs play a crucial role in increasing accessibility and success in higher education, with students and parents consistently reporting positive experiences and perceptions. However, access to information about ASPs remains a significant barrier, leaving students and their families reliant on informal channels to discover programs. Further, limited program capacity and financial requirements for participation restrict access.

While students and parents report positive experiences and supportive environments, program self-evaluation methods appear informal, highlighting an opportunity for more structured assessment of ASP outcomes. Stakeholder perspectives reveal consensus regarding the needs of students and the methods of support employed by ASPs. However, information gaps between groups remain, particularly concerning information sharing and parental involvement.

To enhance accessibility and effectiveness of ASPs, we provide several recommendations. First, there is a pressing need for formalized channels of information sharing between ASPs, high schools, vocational rehabilitation services and families to ensure that students are fully informed about the opportunities available for them. Expanding program capacity through increased funding and staffing is crucial to meet growing demand for ASP services. Future research should investigate the availability of funding for ASP fees, particularly through state vocational rehabilitation services, and explore the prevalence of ASPs or similar services at the community college level.

Data availability statement

The datasets presented in this study can be found in online repositories. The names of the repository/repositories and accession number(s) can be found in the article/Supplementary Material.

Ethics statement

The studies involving humans were approved by Temple University Institutional Review Board. The studies were conducted in accordance with the local legislation and institutional requirements. The participants provided their written informed consent to participate in this study.

Author contributions

MW: Formal analysis, Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Investigation,

Project administration, Data curation. KK: Formal analysis, Data curation, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Conceptualization, Writing – review & editing. MT: Formal analysis, Writing – original draft, Data curation, Supervision, Methodology, Investigation, Writing – review & editing, Funding acquisition, Conceptualization. DH: Writing – review & editing, Methodology, Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Data curation, Investigation, Conceptualization, Funding acquisition, Supervision. ED: Funding acquisition, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Writing – review & editing, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Methodology.

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Supplementary material

The Supplementary Material for this article can be found online at: https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/feduc.2026.1921007/full#supplementary-material

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